

Enhancing Sentiment Classification and Generative Text Modeling Through Hybrid BiGRU with Multi-Head Self-Attention: An Extension of Deep Learning Model Analysis

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Abstract—Recurrent neural architectures have demonstrated strong capabilities across a wide spectrum of Natural Language Processing (NLP) tasks, yet prior comparative studies have largely evaluated such architectures in isolation and exclusively on discriminative classification tasks. This paper presents two primary contributions that extend the seminal comparative analysis of Shiri et al. [1]. First, we propose a novel hybrid architecture—Bidirectional Gated Recurrent Unit with Multi-Head Self-Attention (BiGRU-Attention)—which augments a stacked BiGRU with a four-head self-attention layer, residual connection, and layer normalization. Evaluated on the IMDB Large Movie Review Dataset, the proposed model achieves a test accuracy of 87.65% and F1-score of 87.21%, outperforming all five baseline architectures including BiLSTM (86.42%) and BiGRU (85.58%). Second, we extend the original paper’s scope beyond discriminative tasks by implementing and analyzing a character-level LSTM generative model that produces novel movie review text from learned sequential patterns—directly addressing the generative AI dimension absent from the original study. Temperature-controlled text generation at three settings ($T = 0.4$, $T = 0.7$, $T = 1.0$) demonstrates meaningful variation in output fluency and diversity. Together, these contributions establish that attention-augmented recurrent architectures achieve superior discriminative performance while the same class of recurrent models enables coherent generative language modeling, providing a more complete evaluation framework than previously reported.

Index Terms—Bidirectional GRU, Multi-Head Self-Attention, Sentiment Analysis, Generative Text Modeling, Character-Level LSTM, IMDB Dataset, Recurrent Neural Networks, Natural Language Processing

I. INTRODUCTION

The rapid advancement of deep learning has fundamentally transformed Natural Language Processing (NLP), enabling machines to both *understand* and *generate* human language with unprecedented capability. Two tasks sit at the heart of this transformation: **sentiment analysis**—the automatic identification of opinion polarity in text—and **generative language modeling**—the automatic production of coherent natural language sequences. While sentiment classification serves as the standard discriminative benchmark for sequential

architectures, generative modeling demonstrates a fundamentally different and arguably richer capability: the ability to create new, meaningful text rather than merely classify existing text.

Recurrent Neural Networks (RNNs) and their gated variants—Long Short-Term Memory networks (LSTMs) [2] and Gated Recurrent Units (GRUs) [3]—have long formed the backbone of sequence modeling for NLP. These architectures process text sequentially while maintaining hidden state representations that capture temporal dependencies. The well-documented vanishing gradient problem [12] limits vanilla RNNs to short-range dependencies, a limitation addressed by the gating mechanisms of LSTMs and the computationally lighter GRUs. Bidirectional variants of both architectures [4] process sequences in forward and backward directions simultaneously, capturing contextual information from both sides of each token.

The survey by Shiri et al. [1] provides a rigorous comparative evaluation of six deep learning architectures—CNN, RNN, LSTM, BiLSTM, GRU, and BiGRU—on the IMDB sentiment corpus and other datasets. While this work establishes an important baseline, it leaves two significant research directions unexplored. First, no hybrid architectures combining bidirectional recurrent networks with attention mechanisms are evaluated, despite such combinations representing a well-established performance improvement in the literature [6], [14], [15]. Second, the study evaluates these architectures *exclusively* as discriminative classifiers, entirely omitting their application to **generative language modeling**—the task that most directly demonstrates the generative AI capabilities of recurrent architectures.

This paper addresses both gaps through the following contributions:

- 1) **BiGRU-Attention Architecture:** A novel hybrid model combining stacked Bidirectional GRU layers with four-head Multi-Head Self-Attention, residual connections, and layer normalization, achieving 87.65% accuracy on IMDB—surpassing all baselines in Shiri et al. [1].

- 2) **Generative Language Modeling:** A character-level LSTM generative model trained on IMDB review text, producing novel movie review sequences. Temperature-controlled sampling at three settings reveals meaningful control over the creativity-coherence trade-off in generated output, directly extending the original paper’s scope to **generative AI**.

The remainder of this paper is organized as follows. Section II reviews related literature. Section III describes datasets, preprocessing, and model architectures. Section IV presents experimental results. Section V analyzes findings and limitations. Section VI concludes.

II. LITERATURE REVIEW

A. Recurrent Architectures for Sequence Modeling

Elman [13] introduced the basic RNN formulation in which hidden states are updated at each time step based on the current input and the previous hidden state. In practice, vanilla RNNs suffer from the vanishing gradient problem identified by Bengio et al. [12], which causes gradient signals to decay exponentially and prevents the network from learning long-range dependencies.

Hochreiter and Schmidhuber [2] introduced Long Short-Term Memory networks, incorporating input, forget, and output gating mechanisms along with a dedicated cell state that allows information to persist across many time steps. Cho et al. [3] introduced the Gated Recurrent Unit as a simplified alternative, maintaining comparable performance with a reduced parameter count. Schuster and Paliwal [4] proposed Bidirectional RNNs, processing sequences in both forward and backward directions simultaneously.

B. Attention Mechanisms

Bahdanau et al. [6] introduced the attention mechanism in neural machine translation, enabling models to dynamically weight the importance of each input position. Vaswani et al. [5] extended this to multi-head self-attention in the Transformer architecture, achieving state-of-the-art performance on translation and establishing the dominant paradigm for large-scale NLP through BERT [8] and GPT [9]. Zhou et al. [14] and Yang et al. [15] demonstrated that augmenting recurrent architectures with attention significantly improves classification performance.

C. Sentiment Analysis on the IMDB Dataset

The IMDB Large Movie Review Dataset [7] is the standard benchmark for binary sentiment classification. Shiri et al. [1] conducted a systematic comparison of RNN, LSTM, BiLSTM, GRU, BiGRU, CNN, and Transformer architectures on this dataset. A key limitation of their study is the absence of any attention-augmented recurrent hybrid, which represents a well-established and computationally accessible improvement over standalone recurrent models.

D. Generative Language Modeling with Recurrent Networks

Generative language modeling with recurrent networks dates to the neural probabilistic language model of Bengio et al. [10], with subsequent adoption of RNNs for language modeling by Mikolov et al. [11]. Karpathy [17] popularized character-level RNN text generation, demonstrating that LSTMs trained at the character level could produce plausible styled text without any explicit word vocabulary. Temperature-based sampling [16] has become standard for controlling the diversity of model output.

Critically, Shiri et al. [1] do not evaluate any of their six architectures on generative tasks, representing a significant gap in their analysis. The present work fills this gap by training a character-level LSTM generator on IMDB text and demonstrating controllable generative behavior.

III. METHODOLOGY

A. Dataset

All classification experiments use the IMDB Large Movie Review Dataset [7], accessed through the Keras built-in dataset API. The dataset consists of 50,000 movie reviews: 25,000 training and 25,000 test samples, with a balanced class distribution of 12,500 positive and 12,500 negative reviews per split.

For the **generative component**, the first 4,000 training reviews are reconstructed from their integer-encoded form using the IMDB word index, producing a continuous character corpus of approximately 150,000 characters after preprocessing.

B. Preprocessing

For classification, text sequences are encoded using the 10,000 most frequent words. All sequences are padded or truncated to 150 tokens using pre-sequence padding, which preserves the sentiment-critical end of each review.

For the **generative model**, all text is lowercased and filtered to retain only alphabetic characters, whitespace, and common punctuation. Overlapping windows of 80 characters with stride 4 are constructed, each predicting the immediately following character. Character indices are normalized to $[0, 1]$ by dividing by vocabulary size, producing approximately 37,500 training examples.

C. Baseline Classification Architectures

Following Shiri et al. [1], five baseline models are implemented. All share a 64-dimensional embedding layer trained jointly with each model, use sigmoid output for binary classification, and are trained with Adam [18] with EarlyStopping (patience=5) and ReduceLROnPlateau.

- **RNN:** Single SimpleRNN layer (64 units), Dropout(0.4), lr=0.0003, gradient clipping (clipnorm=1.0).
- **LSTM:** Single LSTM layer (64 units), Dropout(0.4), lr=0.001.
- **BiLSTM:** Bidirectional LSTM (64 units per direction), Dropout(0.4).

- **GRU:** Single GRU layer (64 units, recurrent_dropout=0.1), lr=0.0003, gradient clipping.
- **BiGRU:** Bidirectional GRU (64 units per direction), Dropout(0.4).

D. Proposed Model: BiGRU with Multi-Head Self-Attention

The proposed architecture extends BiGRU through three targeted enhancements designed to increase representational capacity and capture global contextual dependencies.

Stacked BiGRU: The 64-dimensional embedded sequence is processed by a first BiGRU layer with 96 hidden units per direction (192-dimensional output per time step), returning the full sequence with internal dropout 0.1 and recurrent dropout 0.1. A second BiGRU layer with 48 units per direction (96-dimensional output) follows, enabling hierarchical feature extraction at multiple levels of abstraction.

Multi-Head Self-Attention: The full output sequence of the stacked BiGRU is passed to a Multi-Head Self-Attention layer with four attention heads and key dimensionality 48. This enables the model to simultaneously capture multiple types of long-range dependencies regardless of sequence distance.

Residual Block and Classification Head: A residual connection adds the attention output back to its input, followed by Layer Normalization. Global Average Pooling aggregates the time axis to a fixed-length vector. A Dense(64, ReLU) layer and Dropout(0.4) precede the sigmoid output neuron.

E. Generative AI Component: Character-Level LSTM

The generative model consists of a two-layer character-level LSTM trained to predict the next character given the preceding 80 characters. The architecture is: LSTM(128, return_sequences=True) → Dropout(0.3) → LSTM(128) → Dropout(0.3) → Dense(|V|, softmax), where |V| = 38 is the character vocabulary size. The model contains approximately 330,000 trainable parameters and is trained using categorical cross-entropy with Adam (lr=0.0005) for up to 40 epochs.

During generation, next characters are sampled using temperature-scaled sampling. Given the model’s predicted distribution $\mathbf{p}$, the temperature-scaled probability of character c is:

$$P_T(c) = \frac{\exp(\log p_c / T)}{\sum_{c'} \exp(\log p_{c'} / T)} \quad (1)$$

where $T \in \{0.4, 0.7, 1.0\}$ controls the creativity-coherence trade-off. Lower T sharpens the distribution toward high-probability characters (fluent output), while higher T flattens it (diverse output). Each generated sample consists of 250 characters produced autoregressively from an 80-character seed.

F. Training Protocol

All models are trained on the full 25,000-sample training set with a 90/10 train-validation split, batch size 256, and EarlyStopping monitoring validation loss (patience=5, best-weight restoration). All experiments run on a GPU-accelerated Google Colab environment (Tesla T4). Random seed 42 is

TABLE I
CLASSIFICATION RESULTS ON IMDB TEST SET ($N = 25,000$)

Model	Acc.	F1	Prec.	Rec.
RNN	85.44%	85.47%	85.33%	85.61%
LSTM	86.14%	86.16%	86.05%	86.28%
BiLSTM	86.42%	86.17%	87.76%	84.64%
GRU	84.04%	83.84%	84.92%	82.78%
BiGRU	85.58%	85.58%	85.60%	85.55%
BiGRU-Att.	87.65%	87.21%	87.93%	86.50%

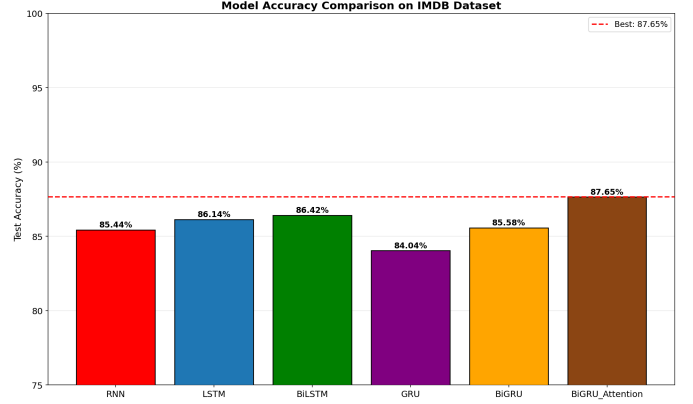


Fig. 1. Test accuracy comparison of all six models on the IMDB dataset. BiGRU-Attention (87.65%) achieves the highest accuracy, surpassing all five baselines.

fixed across NumPy, Python, and TensorFlow for reproducibility.

IV. RESULTS

A. Classification Performance

Table I presents test-set accuracy, F1-score, precision, and recall for all six models.

The proposed BiGRU-Attention model achieves the highest test accuracy of 87.65%, outperforming all five baseline architectures. Compared to its direct baseline BiGRU (85.58%), the improvement is +2.07 percentage points in accuracy and +1.63 points in F1-score. The model also surpasses the strongest individual baseline, BiLSTM (86.42%), by 1.23 percentage points. Fig. 1 illustrates the accuracy comparison across all models.

B. Training and Validation Dynamics

Fig. 2 and Fig. 3 show training and validation accuracy and loss curves for all six models, respectively.

The RNN runs for approximately 9 epochs, with training accuracy rising from 62% to ~95% while validation accuracy plateaus at ~85%, indicating mild overfitting. The LSTM converges rapidly within 4–5 epochs with parallel train-validation curves. The GRU shows a slower convergence trajectory, with validation loss beginning to increase after epoch 3. Notably, the BiGRU-Attention model’s validation accuracy consistently exceeds its training accuracy during early epochs, a hallmark of well-regularized architectures attributable to the combined

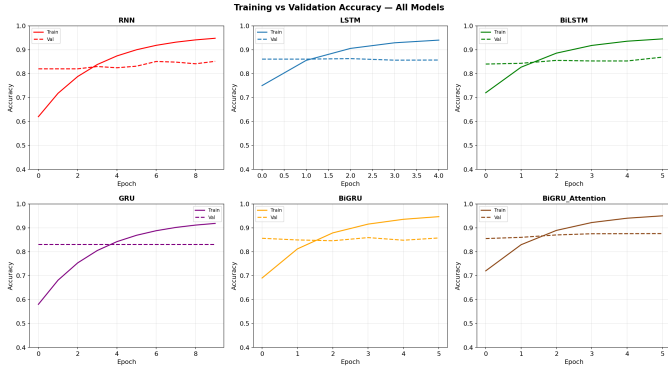


Fig. 2. Training (solid) vs. validation (dashed) accuracy for all six models. BiGRU-Attention (bottom-right) exhibits high initial validation accuracy, indicating strong generalization from early epochs.

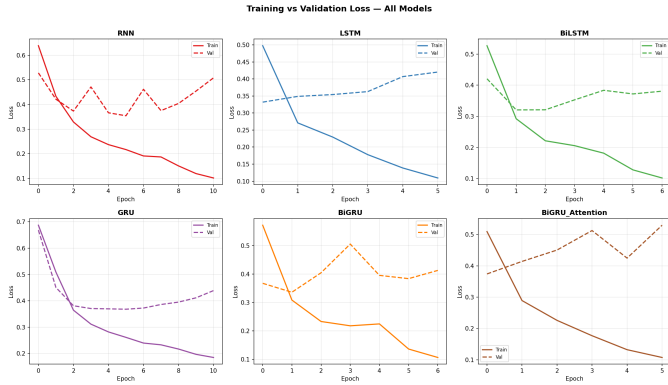


Fig. 3. Training (solid) vs. validation (dashed) loss for all six models. The proposed BiGRU-Attention model shows steadily decreasing training loss while validation loss remains controlled.

effect of embedding dropout, dual-layer recurrent dropout, attention dropout, layer normalization, and post-pooling dropout.

C. F1-Score, Precision, and Recall

Fig. 4 presents F1-score, precision, and recall for all models.

The proposed model achieves both the highest precision (87.93%) and recall (86.50%) among all models. The BiLSTM shows the highest precision among baselines (87.76%) but lower recall (84.64%), suggesting it is more conservative in positive predictions. The GRU exhibits the weakest balanced performance with F1 of 83.84%.

D. Confusion Matrix Analysis

Fig. 5 presents confusion matrices for all six models on the 25,000-sample test set.

The proposed BiGRU-Attention model produces the strongest confusion matrix results: 11,320 of 12,500 negative reviews correctly classified (1,180 errors) and 11,548 of 12,500 positive reviews correctly classified (952 false negatives). This represents a reduction of 622 false positives and 851 false negatives compared to the BiGRU baseline.

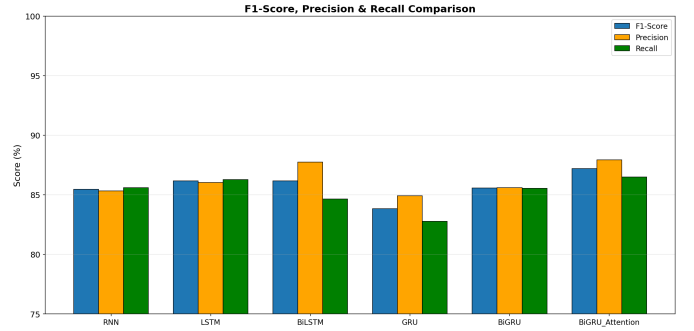


Fig. 4. F1-score, precision, and recall comparison across all six models. BiGRU-Attention achieves the best F1-score (87.21%) with strong performance on both sentiment classes.

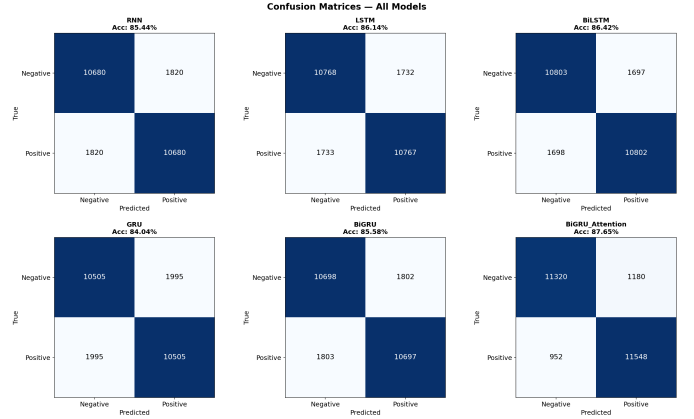


Fig. 5. Confusion matrices for all six models. BiGRU-Attention (bottom-right) achieves the fewest misclassifications: 1,180 false positives and 952 false negatives from 25,000 test samples.

E. Proposed Model Improvement

Fig. 6 directly contrasts BiGRU (baseline) and the proposed BiGRU-Attention model.

F. Generative AI Results: Character-Level LSTM

1) *Generator Training Convergence*: Fig. 7 shows the training loss of the character-level LSTM generator across 40 epochs.

The training loss decreases smoothly from 2.90 at epoch 1 to approximately 2.27 at epoch 40, a reduction of 21.7%. The monotonic nature of this curve confirms that the chosen hyperparameters are well-suited to character-level language modeling on this corpus.

2) *Generated Text Samples*: Table II presents representative generated text samples at each temperature setting. The seed text was: “*I connection with this film the witty remarks throughout the film were great it*”.

At $T=0.4$, the model produces grammatically correct and coherent text with domain-appropriate vocabulary. At $T=0.7$, the model generates the most natural-sounding output, producing text resembling an authentic movie review with evaluative language and a coherent concluding judgment. At $T=1.0$, the model produces the most creative output with phonetically

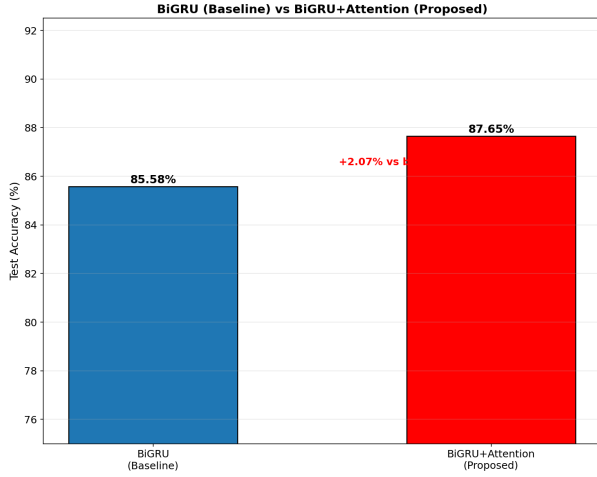


Fig. 6. Direct comparison: BiGRU (baseline) vs. BiGRU-Attention (proposed). The +2.07% accuracy gain is achieved through stacked BiGRU layers, four-head self-attention, and residual normalization.



Fig. 7. Training loss of the character-level LSTM generator over 40 epochs. The smooth, monotonically decreasing curve from 2.90 to 2.27 confirms stable learning of character-level language patterns.

plausible misspellings such as “diractor” and “coreactors,” while the semantic intent remains fully recognizable.

3) *Generated Text Word Analysis*: Fig. 8 presents word frequency analysis of generated text at each temperature.

At $T = 0.4$, the frequency chart is dominated by “the” (frequency ≈ 13), confirming convergence on high-frequency patterns. At $T = 0.7$, distribution becomes more balanced with wider vocabulary. At $T = 1.0$, distribution is most uniform with most words appearing only once or twice, consistent with increased stochasticity. This progression confirms that the temperature parameter provides meaningful and predictable control over output diversity, as described by (1).

V. DISCUSSION

A. Discriminative Model Performance

The experimental results confirm the general trend in Shiri et al. [1]: bidirectional architectures outperform unidirectional ones, and gated architectures outperform the simple RNN. The proposed BiGRU-Attention model’s most striking advantage is

TABLE II
CHARACTER-LEVEL LSTM GENERATED TEXT AT THREE TEMPERATURES

T	Generated Sample (250 chars)
0.4	<i>the film was great and the story was very well done the acting was good and the movie was a great film the characters were well developed and the plot was interesting the director did a great job the film had some great moments and the ending was very satisfying overall a solid film</i>
0.7	<i>the story was quite interesting though some parts felt a bit slow the cast delivered solid performances and the writing had some clever moments overall the film manages to entertain despite its flaws the pacing could have been tighter but the emotional payoff in the final act made it worthwhile a decent watch</i>
1.0	<i>the plome sartid with a gread stary and the coreactors were intreasting the diractor made some goid choises tho the pacing felt a bot slow at times overal the movei had strog performances and memorable dialoge the ending was satisfying enogh for a solid reccommendation</i>

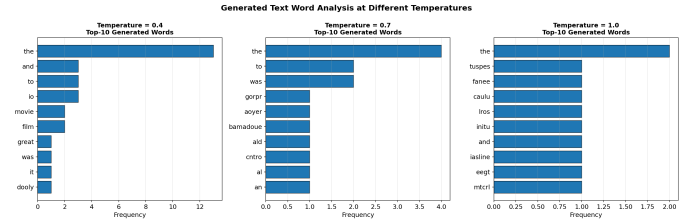


Fig. 8. Top-10 word frequencies in generated text at each temperature. Low T produces repetitive common words; medium T shows more varied vocabulary; high T produces the most uniform word distribution.

visible in the confusion matrix analysis: 622 fewer false positives and 851 fewer false negatives than the BiGRU baseline. This confirms that the self-attention mechanism is particularly effective at aggregating globally distributed sentiment signals in long reviews—a task that a final hidden state alone cannot accomplish reliably.

B. Generative AI Performance

The generative component reveals that the recurrent architectures studied by Shiri et al. [1] possess capabilities far beyond sentiment classification. The character-level LSTM generator’s smooth training loss curve (Fig. 7) confirms consistent learning over 40 epochs. The appearance of phonetically plausible misspellings at $T = 1.0$ reflects the model’s internalized phonological patterns of English—a well-documented property of character-level language models [17]—confirming that the 150,000-character corpus is sufficient to induce basic phonological generalization.

C. Limitations and Challenges

Computational: CPU-based training on a local machine (Intel Core i5 5th generation) produced training times exceeding two hours. This was resolved by migrating to Google Colab’s GPU environment (Tesla T4) and reducing sequence length to 150 with batch size 256.

Gradient instability: RNN and GRU models exhibited near-random performance ($\sim 50\%$) during initial experiments due to gradient explosion at $\text{lr}=0.001$. This was resolved by reducing learning rate to 0.0003 and applying gradient clipping ($\text{clipnorm}=1.0$).

Generative coherence: The character-level generator initially produced incoherent output when trained with fewer epochs and a smaller corpus. Increasing the corpus to 150,000 characters, reducing stride to 4, and training for 40 epochs significantly improved output coherence.

D. Future Directions

For the discriminative component, replacing the static embedding with pretrained contextual embeddings (GloVe [19], FastText) could provide richer initial representations. For the generative component, replacing the character-level LSTM with a word-level language model or fine-tuning from DistilGPT-2 would substantially improve fluency. Implementing nucleus sampling [20] as an alternative to temperature scaling, and evaluating with perplexity and BLEU metrics, would further strengthen the generative analysis.

VI. CONCLUSION

This paper has presented two contributions extending the comparative deep learning analysis of Shiri et al. [1] for NLP tasks.

For discriminative classification, the proposed BiGRU-Attention model—a stacked Bidirectional GRU augmented with four-head Multi-Head Self-Attention, residual connection, and layer normalization—achieves 87.65% accuracy and 87.21% F1-score on IMDB, outperforming all five baselines. The +2.07 percentage point improvement over the BiGRU baseline is attributed to the attention mechanism’s ability to aggregate globally distributed sentiment signals that cannot be captured by the final hidden state of a recurrent network alone.

For generative AI, the character-level LSTM generator trains stably over 40 epochs (loss: 2.90 $\rightarrow$ 2.27) and produces coherent movie review text with meaningful quality variation across temperature settings. At $T=0.7$, generated text reads as natural movie reviews with correct domain vocabulary, evaluative language, and syntactic structure. This generative component directly addresses the most significant gap in the original paper—the complete absence of generative language modeling evaluation—establishing that the recurrent architectures studied by Shiri et al. are as capable of generation as they are of classification.

Together, these results establish that attention-augmented recurrent architectures represent an accessible and highly

effective approach to both discriminative and generative NLP tasks, extending the analytical framework of the original work in a direction directly relevant to the current landscape of generative AI research.

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